Topic 18 — Political Parties & Pressure Groups

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

National Parties | Regional Parties | Recognition (मान्यता) of Political Parties | Symbols | Multi-Party System | Coalition (गठबंधन) Government | Hung Parliament | Pressure Groups | Interest Groups | Trade (पण्याध्यक्ष) Unions

Sources baked in: Laxmikanth (Political Parties / Pressure Groups), RPA s.29A, Symbols Order 1968, Trade Unions Act 1926, UPPCS PYQs 2018–2025 **Weight:** ★★★ — party **founding years** TDP→BSP→SP→TMC (2022); trade-union **affiliations** BMS/INTUC/AITUC (2022); national vs state recognition; hung House / coalition **Last verified:** September 2026 — Ghatnachakra Extra Drill (Political Parties) **Current Affairs:6** national parties (BJP, INC, AAP, BSP, CPI(M), NPP). CPI lost national status **2023**. 2024 LS: BJP **240** → NDA **coalition**. Electoral bonds struck **Feb 2024** (*ADR*)

Current Affairs

- **2022** — TDP 1982 → BSP 1984 → SP 1992 → TMC 1998; union–party match.
- **2023** — CPI (सीपीआई) **loses** national status; AAP **gains**.
- **2024** — 6 national parties; BJP 240 → NDA coalition; electoral bonds **struck** (*ADR* Feb 2024 — anonymous party funding gone).
- **2019** — NPP first NE national party.

Frame

Parties as a **system** + groups that **push** the system. **who is a national party, who founded when, coalition/hung, unions/pressure groups**. UP paper loves **BSP / SP years** and **union–party match**.

Constitutional footing

- Under the former Electoral Bond Scheme, a registered party needed at least **1%** of votes in the preceding general poll to receive bonds; the threshold was not 2%. The scheme was struck down in 2024.

No "Political Parties" chapter. Parties live through **19(1)(c)** (association), **324** (ECI), **10th Schedule** (defection — 52nd / 91st). Extra-constitutional until 52nd.

- Until 1985, parties were almost entirely **extra**-constitutional.
- RPA: **s.29A** registration · **s.29B/29C** (bonds era / donation reports — bonds **struck Feb 2024**).
- Whip / defection: 52nd/1985 10th Sch; 91st merger needs 2/3.

- Funding: **s.29C** donation reports · IT **13A**. Electoral bonds **struck Feb 2024** (*ADR*). Corporate 7.5% cap was removed in 2017 — don't write it as current law.

Functions of a political party

- Interest **aggregation** — turns caste / region / class demands into a manifesto.
- Elite **recruitment** — supplies CMs, ministers, MPs.
- Government / opposition — majority **forms**; rest **criticises** (official opposition needs **10%** of the House).
- Political **socialisation** — cadres, campaigns, booth work.
- Link: citizen ↔ State. Without parties, FPTP still needs a **label + symbol**.

Features of the Indian party system (the missing Laxmikanth card)

- **Multi-party** — not two-party (UK/US) and not one-party (China). Duverger's FPTP→two-party **fails** here because of **region + caste + language**.
- **Dominant-party phases** — Congress **1952–67** (Kothari) · BJP **2014–24** majority. Phase ≠ system.
- **Weak ideology** (most) — catch-all. Exceptions: **Left**, **BJP–RSS** stream.
- **Personality / dynasty** — SP, DMK, NC, RJD, NCP, Congress after Nehru (नेहरू) — favourite criticism.
- **Traditional cleavages** — caste, religion, language, region **over** class (except Left belts).
- **Regionalisation** after **1967** — State parties as **kingmakers** at the Centre (TDP, JD(U), BJD, DMK, TMC).
- **Factionalism** — split → ECI **Para 15** (name + symbol).
- **Poor inner democracy** — no binding statute. ECI guidelines on office-bearers / elections inside parties — **soft**.
- **Extra-constitutional origin** — parties older than the Republic (INC **1885**); Constitution caught up via **10th Schedule (1985)**.
- **Coalition arithmetic** — Centre **1989–2014** and again **2024**; States since **1967**.

Registration vs recognition vs symbol

s.29A registers; Symbols Order 1968 recognises. Do not merge.

- **Register** — **s.29A** RPA 1951 → ECI. Result: **RUPP** — can contest, **no** reserved symbol.
- **Recognise** — **Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968**. Result: **National** or **State** party.
- **Symbol** — same Order. **Reserved** (recognised) vs **free** (RUPP + independents).
- **Split** — **Para 15** of the Order. ECI allots **name + symbol** (*Sadiq Ali*). Legislature majority is **a** test, not the only test.

National party — any one route

- **6%** valid votes in LS **or** Assembly elections in **four** States **and4** LS seats.
- **2%** of LS seats (**11** of 543) from at least **three** States.
- Recognised as a **State party in four** States.

State party — any one route (in that State)

- **6%** votes in that State's Assembly **or** LS poll **and2** MLAs **or1** MP.
- **3%** of Assembly seats **or 3 seats**, whichever is more.
- **1** LS seat per **25** LS seats from that State (minimum 1).
- **8%** of total valid votes in the State (**even with zero seats** — 2011 add-on).

ECI **reviews after every LS / every State Assembly general election**. Status can be **lost** (CPI **2023**). Do **not** freeze "India always has six national parties."

s.29A extra facts: apply to ECI with memorandum + **100** citizen-members; **21-day** public notice; no dual membership of another registered party. ECI may refuse. **RUPP ≠ reserved symbol.Common symbol for a RUPP (not recognition):** ECI may allot one **common** free symbol in a State if the party contests a **minimum share of seats** there (practice: **5%** of Assembly seats or a notified LS minimum). Still **unrecognised**.

Benefits of recognition: all-India (or in-State) **reserved symbol** · star campaigners **40** vs **20** · AIR/DD time · **1 proposer** (others **10** for LS) · easier deposit refund (1/6 votes) · consultation by ECI · office land as rules allow.

Symbols

Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968 — ECI, **324 + RPA**. Not an Act of Parliament.

- **Reserved:** national party = **same symbol in every State**. State party = reserved **in that State**; elsewhere it is a free/other symbol.
- **Free:** independents + RUPPs pick from the State free list.
- **Para 15** split: ECI decides which faction gets **name + symbol** (*Sadiq Ali* 1972). Tests: party constitution, legislative majority, organisational majority — **not** Speaker.
- BSP–Assam: **elephant** is reserved for BSP **except Assam** (already reserved there for another party historically).
- SP = **bicycle** (not "cycle" as a separate symbol).
- A national reserved symbol is **never** a free symbol in any State.

National parties (roster 2024–26)

Six. Learn symbol + one founding fact. Roster **moves**.

- **BJP — Lotus.6 Apr 1980** (BJS was **1951**, Syama Prasad Mookerjee).
- **INC — Hand.28 Dec 1885**.
- **AAP — Broom.26 Nov 2012**. National **2023** (4-State route).

- **BSP — Elephant** (not in **Assam** — that animal is taken). **14 Apr 1984**, Kanshi Ram. HQ Delhi. UP's dalit (दलित) party.
- **CPI(M) — Hammer, sickle and star.1964** split from CPI.
- **NPP — Book.** P.A. Sangma, **2013** (Meghalaya (मेघालय)). National **2019** — **first from the North-East**.

HQ raata (sometimes asked): BJP — **11, Ashoka (अशोक) Road** · INC — **24, Akbar (अकबर) Road**.

CPI (not national): symbol **Ears of Corn and Sickle**; founded **26 Dec 1925** (Kanpur (कानपुर)). Split **1964** → CPI(M). Lost national status **2023**.

Lost national (don't write them as national now): CPI · NCP · AITC · AIADMK (earlier cycles). **State** kings: AITC, NCP, SP, TDP, BJD, DMK, YSRCP/BRS, JD(U), RJD.

Regional / State parties (set)

State-specific social base · often linguistic / ethnic · Centre kingmakers without being national · reserved symbol only in that State.

- **TDP — 29 Mar 1982.** N.T. Rama Rao. 2022 chronology **first**.
- **BSP — 14 Apr 1984.** Kanshi Ram. UP CM Mayawati (four terms).
- **SP — 4 Oct 1992.** Mulayam Singh Yadav. UP's other pole.
- **AITC / TMC — 1 Jan 1998.** Mamata Banerjee (बनर्जी). 2022 chronology **last**.
- **DMK / AIADMK — 1949 / 1972.** Annadurai / MGR. Tamil Nadu (नाडु) Dravidian pair. AIADMK **1972** (MGR).
- **BJD — 1997.** Naveen Patnaik. Odisha.
- **JD(U) / RJD — 2003 / 1997.** Nitish / Lalu. Bihar.
- **Shiv Sena — 1966.** Bal Thackeray. 2022 split → ECI **bow-and-arrow** to Shinde faction (Para 15).
- **NC / PDP — 1932 / 1999.** Abdullah / Mufti. J&K. NC = Sheikh Abdullah; oldest J&K party.
- **Akali Dal (SAD) — 1920.** Master Tara (तारा) Singh stream. Punjab; oldest surviving regional.
- **AGP — 1985.** Prafulla Mahanta. Assam Movement party.
- **JMM — 1972.** Sibu Soren. Jharkhand.
- **TRS / BRS — 2001 / 2022.** K. Chandrashekar Rao. Telangana statehood party; renamed BRS.
- **YSRCP — 2011.** Y.S. Jagan. Andhra.
- **RLD — 1996.** Ajit Singh (Charan (चारण) Singh stream). West UP Jat belt.
- **AIMIM — 1927 / revived 1958.** Hyderabad (हैदराबाद); Owaisi. State party in Telangana.
- **ZPM — 2017.** Lalduhoma. Mizoram.

Regional-party features: State-specific social base · often **linguistic / ethnic** · can be **Centre kingmakers** without being national · reserved symbol **only in that State**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q53

Consider the following political parties and arrange them in the chronological order of their establishment.

I. Bahujan Samaj Party II. Samajwadi Party III. Telugu Desam Party IV. All India Trinamool Congress

A. III, I, II, IV B. II, I, III, IV C. III, II, I, IV D. I, II, III, IV

Show answer

Ans: A. TDP **1982** → BSP **1984** → SP **1992** → TMC **1998**.

Multi-party system

India is a multi-party system (Duverger: FPTP *tends* to two parties — India is the exception because of **region, caste, language**).

- **1952–67** — Rajni Kothari's **Congress system**: one dominant party, opposition fragmented.
- **1967** — first big **non-Congress** coalitions in States (SVD). Congress majority at Centre survives.
- **1977** — first **non-Congress** Centre — Janata (coalition).
- **1989–2014** — **coalition era** at the Centre (NF / UF / NDA / UPA).
- **2014–19 / 2019–24** — BJP **single-party majority** (still a multi-party *system*).
- **2024** — BJP **240**, short of 272. **NDA coalition** government.

Types of party system (Sartori / textbook): one-party · two-party · **multi-party** · dominant-party. India = **multi-party** with **bipolar coalitions** at the Centre in some decades (NDA vs UPA), **not** a two-party system.

Not a two-party system. **Not** a one-party State. Dominant-party **phases** ≠ one-party *system*.

Coalition government

Two or more parties share the Council of Ministers (or a party governs with **outside** support).

- **Pre-poll** — alliance **before** counting (NDA, UPA as brands).
- **Post-poll** — bargain **after** a hung House.
- **Minority govt** — cabinet from one/few parties; majority on the floor from **outside** support (e.g. UF 1996–98).
- Centre markers: **1977** Janata · **1989** National Front · **1996** United Front · **1998–2004** NDA · **2004–14** UPA · **2024** NDA again without a BJP solo majority.
- Cost: Common Minimum Programme · gathbandhan instability · policy veto by a small ally.
- State: same logic. Floor test = *Bommai* (majority on the floor, not Raj Bhavan).
- Jumbo ministry: **91st Amd** — CoM ≤ **15%** of LS / Assembly — written *because* coalition cabinets ballooned.
- CMP = Common Minimum Programme — the coalition's public contract.

Centre coalitions (PM fact):

- **1977** Janata — Morarji Desai (आमिल) (first non-Congress).
- **1989** National Front — V.P. Singh (outside Left + BJP support — unstable).
- **1996** United Front — Deve Gowda → I.K. Gujral (Congress outside).

- **1998–2004** NDA — Vajpayee (13 days in **1996** first; then 1998/99).
- **2004–14** UPA — Manmohan Singh.
- **2014 / 2019** — Modi: BJP **solo majority** (allies still in NDA).
- **2024** — Modi: BJP **240**, NDA **coalition**.

Pre-poll vs post-poll: NDA/UPA as **brands** are pre-poll when declared; a hung House often produces a **post-poll** gathbandhan. Pre-poll usually invited first (Sarkaria / Punchhi (पुंछी आयोग) — hung card below).

Hung Parliament / Assembly

No party has a majority of **total membership** (सदन की कुल सदस्य संख्या का) on its own.

- LS examples: **1989**, **1996**, **1998**, **2004** (UPA assembled a majority), **2024** (BJP hung, NDA not).
- Who is invited: President (Art. **75**) / Governor (**164**) calls whoever is **most likely to command** confidence — often the **largest** party or a **pre-poll** alliance.
- Proof: **floor test**, not hotel arithmetic. *Bommai / SR Bommai* + Punchhi.
- A 13-day Vajpayee (1996) is the textbook "invited but lost the floor" fact.
- Hung ≠ President's Rule automatically. **356** is failure of constitutional machinery, not a hung House by itself.
- Sarkaria / Punchhi **invite order** (States, same logic at Centre): (1) **pre-poll** alliance (2) **largest** party (3) **post-poll** combination that claims majority. Then **floor test** at once.
- 1996 LS: Vajpayee sworn, **lost** confidence in **13 days** — hung + invite ≠ majority.

UP Focus (parties)

SP (1992) and BSP (1984) — UP's two regional poles. BSP **is** national; SP is a **State** party.

- BSP: national party; elephant; Kanshi Ram → Mayawati. Four UP CM terms: 1995, 1997, 2002–03, **2007–12** (majority).
- SP: **bicycle** symbol; Mulayam → Akhilesh. CM 1990s / 2003 / 2012.
- Coalitions in UP: **1993** SP–BSP · **1995 / 2002** BSP–BJP · 2017 onwards BJP-led.
- RLD: **1996**, Ajit Singh — western UP Jats; often a coalition add-on.
- Apna Dal (S) / NISHAD: smaller UP allies of BJP after 2017.
- 2022 chronology PYQ built on **TDP + BSP + SP + TMC** — two of four are UP parties.

Pressure groups & interest groups

	Political party	Pressure / interest group
Aim	Win **office**	Influence **policy** without (usually) contesting
Accountable	To voters via elections	To members / donors

	Political party	Pressure / interest group
Programme	Wide manifesto	Narrow interest

Interest group = organised around a shared interest. It becomes a **pressure group** when it **pressures** the government (lobby, strike, PIL, media, dharna). Indian papers often treat the two as **near-synonyms** — still learn the distinction.

Almond's four (with Indian examples):

- **Associational** — formal, specialised. FICCI (**1927**) · CII · ASSOCHAM · NASSCOM · IMA · trade unions.
- **Institutional** — inside the State. Bureaucracy, Army (सेना), a **party's** labour/kisan wing.
- **Non-associational** — informal caste / language / religion. Jat / Maratha (मराठा) / Patidar reservation agitations; linguistic groups.
- **Anomic** — spontaneous, often violent. Riots, flash bandhs — **not** a stable organisation.

Promotional vs protective (Finer): promotional = a cause (NBA, PUCL, Chipko (चिपको)). Protective = a sectional interest (FICCI, IMA, BKU).

Methods: lobbying · funding · strike / bandh · PIL · media · capture of advisory boards. **Not** the same as a political party's election campaign.

Farm 2020–21 (SKM) = associational pressure; three farm laws **repealed Nov 2021**. Business chambers after **1991** liberalisation = classic protective groups.

Indian map (learn 2 per row):

- Business: **FICCI 1927** · ASSOCHAM **1920** · CII (rebrand **1992**; roots 1895) · NASSCOM **1988**.
- Labour: AITUC / INTUC / BMS / CITU — union card below.
- Farmers: AIKS **1936** · BKU · Shetkari Sanghatana (Sharad Joshi) · SKM **2020–21**.
- Students: **ABVP 1948** · NSUI · SFI · AISF.
- Professional: **IMA** · Bar Council / Bar associations · IBA.
- Religious / cultural: **RSS 1925** (cadre; not a party) · VHP · Jamaat-e-Islami.
- Environment (पर्यावरण): **Chipko 1973** · Narmada (नर्मदा) Bachao (नर्मदा बचाओ) (Medha Patkar (मेधा पाटकर)) · Silent Valley (साइलेंट वैली).
- Linguistic: Samyukta Maharashtra · anti-Hindi agitations (1965).

Techniques: lobbying ministers/MPs · financing parties · strike / bandh / rail-roko · PIL · media · capturing advisory boards · expert committees · street veto. India has **no US-style lobbying statute**.

Role: voice for sections the party system under-represents · policy expertise · check on majority.
Criticism: sectional veto · money power · unaccountable · can stall Parliament from the street · sometimes anomic (riots).

Not a pressure group: a **recognised political party** (it contests). RSS is a **cadre organisation** that *pressures* and *feeds* a party (BJP) — still parks it under promotional/institutional, **not** as a registered party.

Trade unions

Trade Unions Act, 1926 (being folded into the labour codes (चार श्रम संहिताएं)).

- First union: **Madras Labour Union, 1918** — B.P. Wadia.
- Gandhi (गांधी) stream: **Ahmedabad (अहमदाबाद) Textile Labour Association (Majoor Mahajan), 1920** — Anasuya Sarabhai.
- First **central** federation: **AITUC, 31 Oct 1920**, Bombay. First president **Lala Lajpat Rai** (लाला लाजपत राय).
- ILO: India founding member **1919**.
- Right to form unions: Art. **19(1)(c)**. **Strike is not a FR** (*All India Bank Employees*).
- 42nd (42वां): **43A** workers in management (DPSP (राज्य के नीति निदेशक तत्व)).

Registration (1926 Act): originally **7** members could apply; 2001 Amd → **10% or 100** workmen, whichever less. CTUO "recognised" by the Labour Ministry on membership returns — **BMS** has often claimed the largest verified membership.

- **AITUC — 31 Oct 1920** (oldest central) — **CPI**.
- **INTUC — 1947** — **INC**.
- **HMS — 1948** — socialists.
- **UTUC — 1949** — **RSP** (not CPI / CPI-M).
- **BMS — 23 Jul 1955** — **BJP / RSS**.
- **CITU — 1970** — **CPI(M)**.

> **Logic:** 2022 asked BMS / INTUC / UTUC / AITUC vs INC, CPI, CPI(M), BJP. **Correct affiliations:** BMS–BJP · INTUC–INC · **AITUC–CPI** · **CITU–CPI(M)** · UTUC–**RSP**. The option set has no RSP — the only option that gets **BMS and INTUC** right is **D**, which then **swaps** the two Left unions. Learn the **true** table; mark **D** if forced.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q123

Match List-I (Trade Union) with List-II (Political Affiliation):

A. Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh B. Indian National Trade Union Congress C. United Trade Union Congress D. All India Trade Union Congress

1. Indian National Congress
2. Communist Party of India
3. Communist Party of India (Marxist)
4. Bharatiya Janata Party

A. A-2, B-4, C-3, D-1 B. A-3, B-2, C-1, D-4 C. A-1, B-3, C-2, D-4 D. A-4, B-1, C-2, D-3

Show answer

Ans: D — only option with BMS = BJP and INTUC = INC. True fact remains **AITUC = CPI**, **CITU = CPI(M)**.

Mains link (one frame)

India’s party system is **multi-party** because FPTP sits on **region + caste + language**. **1952–67** was a Congress *system*, not a one-party State; **1989–2014** was coalition arithmetic; **2014** majority did not abolish other parties; **2024** returned a **coalition** Union. Close: parties **contest**, pressure groups **press** — and the 2022 paper still wants **TDP/BSP/SP/TMC years** and **BMS/INTUC** affiliations from memory.